When Vasco da Gama landed in India, it had a population of around 110 million. At that time, China had an estimated population of 103 million, the United Kingdom 3.9 million and Portugal just 1 million.[9] India was still a major economic power with a share of 24.5 per cent of world GDP. Nonetheless, this was smaller than the one-third share of world GDP that it had enjoyed in the first millennium AD. Around 1500, the Chinese economy bypassed the Indian economy in terms of size for the first time. Moreover, per capita income in India fell below the global average. After having lagged behind India for centuries, most European countries enjoyed higher per capita incomes by 1500. The richest country in Europe, Italy, had a per capita income that was twice the Indian level. The individual brilliance of rulers like Akbar and Krishnadeva Raya may have created periods of prosperity, but it did not reverse the trend. In short, the glittering Mughal court of the sixteenth and seventeenth century hid the fact that India was already in relative decline.

As argued in my previous book, *The Indian Renaissance*, the problem was a growing technological gap between the Europeans and everyone else. The most cutting-edge technology of that time was cartography—the technique of making maps—and the Europeans were simply miles ahead by the beginning of the sixteenth century. The discoveries of the Portuguese were put down on hand-drawn maps and these charts were considered top secret. Before each voyage, the captain was allowed to make a copy from the royal library and was expected to return it with new discoveries marked out when he got back.[10] Not surprisingly, the maps were the focus of international espionage. In 1502, Alberto Cantino, an agent of the Duke of Ferrera, stole a chart from Lisbon and took it to Italy. It is preserved in the Biblioteca Estense of Modena and shows that the Portuguese had quickly worked out that India was a peninsula although many elements of Ptolemaic geography were still retained.

The first map showing the Indian peninsula to be published publicly was by Johan Ruysch in Rome in 1508. It shows India as a peninsula and marks a few of the ports on the coast but shows little knowledge of the country’s